

A dystopian nightmare

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A dystopia is a community or society that is in some important way undesirable or frightening. It is literally translated as “not-good place”, an antonym of utopia. Such societies appear in many artistic works, particularly in stories set in a future. Dystopias are often characterized by dehumanization, totalitarian governments, environmental disaster, or other characteristics associated with a cataclysmic decline in society. Dystopian societies appear in many sub-genres of fiction and are often used to draw attention to real-world issues regarding society, environment, politics, economics, religion, psychology, ethics, science, and/or technology, which if unaddressed could potentially lead to such a dystopia-like condition.

Famous depictions of dystopian societies include R.U.R. (which introduced the concept of robots and the word “robot” for the first time); Nineteen Eighty-Four, which takes place in a totalitarian invasive super state; Brave New World, where the society’s energy is forcibly directed into drug-addled consumerism and hedonism; Fahrenheit 451, where the state burns books to create apathy and disinterest in the general public; A Clockwork Orange, where the state uses psychological torture to reform violent youths; Blade Runner in which engineered “replicants” infiltrate society and must be hunted down before they injure humans; The Matrix, in which the human species is trapped in a virtual reality world created by intelligent machines, The Hunger Games, in which the government controls its people by maintaining a constant state of fear through forcing randomly selected children to participate in an annual fight to the death; Logan’s Run, in which both population and the consumption of resources are maintained in equilibrium by requiring the death of everyone reaching a particular age; Soylent Green, where society suffers from pollution, overpopulation, depleted resources, poverty, dying oceans, a hot climate, and much of the population survives on processed food rations, including “soylent green”.